First Steps to Understanding

Balagah

Hashim Mohamed

Al-Qalam Institute

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Compiler	**Hashim Mohamed**
Contact:	**Al-Qalam Institute**
	6 Sylvan Avenue,
	Leicester, LE5 3SN,
	United Kingdom
Email	admin@alqalaminstitute.org
Website	www.alqalaminstitute.org
YouTube	www.youtube.com/alqalaminstitute

If you see any mistakes in this book, have any comments or suggestions, please feel free to contact us. Jazakallah.

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Foreword

بِسۡمِ ٱللَّهِ ٱلرَّحۡمَٰنِ ٱلرَّحِيمِ

All praise is due to Allah سُبْحَانَهُ وَتَعَالَى, without whose help nothing is possible. Alhamdulillah, only through His grace and bounty, we present the second edition of 'First Steps to Understanding Balagah'.

Who is this book for?

The purpose of this book is to act as an introductory guide to the study of Balagah, the science of eloquence in Arabic.

Its target audience is students who have already acquired a foundation in the Arabic language, specifically in areas such as Nahw (grammar), Sarf (morphology), and Literature.

Resources

The following resources are available on our website to support learning and teaching:

- PDF of this book
- Video recordings and PowerPoints of the lessons from the first edition
- Downloadable exam papers

Acknowledgments

I would like to extend my most sincere appreciation to all those who made this project possible, especially my parents, teachers, the staff and students at Al-Qalam. May Allah سُبْحَانَهُ وَتَعَالَى reward them all in this world and the Hereafter for their contributions and help. Ameen.

I ask Allah سُبْحَانَهُوَتَعَالَىٰ and I also request you all to ask Allah to accept this work, overlook its shortcomings and to make it a means of reward in the Hereafter.

Hashim Mohamed

27th June 2023

9th Zul-Hijjah, 1444

Introduction

The study of the Arabic language can be divided into three layers, namely: Grammar, Balagah, and 'Ijaz.

Grammar

Grammar encompasses Nahw (Syntax) and Sarf (Morphology). In Nahw, the initial discussion revolves around the إِعْرَابٌ of words and their position in a sentence. Sarf, on the other hand, focuses on the structure of words.

Balagah (الْبَلَاغَةُ)

Balagah (الْبَلَاغَةُ) delves into the intricacies of word usage, sentence structure, emphasis placement, speech length and brevity, and other related topics.

It explores, for instance, the appropriate word choice or sentence structure e.g. the positioning of a مَفْعُولٌ بِهِ in relation to the verb.

‘Ijaz (الْإِعْجَازُ)

'Ijaz (الْإِعْجَازُ) is the remarkable utilization of Balagah within the Quran, resulting in a text that is truly miraculous and unparalleled in its form.

Overview of the Science of Balagah

The field of Balagah comprises three distinct sub-sciences:

1) عِلْمُ الْمَعَانِيْ
2) عِلْمُ الْبَيَانِ
3) عِلْمُ الْبَدِيْعِ

The mastery of these three sub-sciences is crucial to comprehend the miraculous nature of the language used in the Quran.

Unit 1

عِلْمُ الْمَعَانِيْ

Introduction

The sub-science of عِلْمُ الْمَعَانِيْ deals with the aspects of Arabic language that are related to the meaning of words, sentences, and their structures. This unit will cover eight topics related to عِلْمُ الْمَعَانِيْ:

1) Parts of a Sentence
2) Types of Sentences
3) Word Order
4) Details of مَعْرِفَةٌ and نَكِرَةٌ
5) Restrictions
6) Joining Sentences
7) Length of Speech
8) Miscellaneous Rules

Part 1
Parts of A Sentence

An Arabic sentence is made up of two types of words:

1. عُمْدَةٌ
2. فَضْلَةٌ

عُمْدَةٌ

The عُمْدَةٌ are the essential parts of a sentence. Without these, a sentence would not be complete.

These are the مُسْنَدٌ إِلَيْهِ and مُسْنَدٌ.

مُسْنَدٌ إِلَيْهِ

The مُسْنَدٌ إِلَيْهِ is the subject of the sentence. This includes both the مُبْتَدَأٌ and فَاعِلٌ.

مُسْنَدٌ

The مُسْنَدٌ is the information regarding the subject. This includes the خَبَرٌ or فِعْلٌ.

فَضْلَةٌ

The remaining parts of a sentence are called فَضْلَةٌ or قَيْدٌ (Plural قُيُوْدٌ). All types of مَفْعُوْلٌ, حَالٌ, تَمْيِيْزٌ, مُسْتَثْنًى, نَوَاسِخُ, شَرْطٌ and words of نَفْيٌ are considered to be فَضْلَةٌ.

Even though the grammar of a sentence is complete without the فَضْلَةٌ, the meaning would not be complete. In fact, the فَضْلَةٌ are usually the focal point of the sentences.

﴿وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا الزِّنَىٰٓ﴾

Do not go near fornication.

In this verse, the word الزِّنَا is the مَفْعُوْلٌ بِهِ, a قَيْدٌ. Without this, the sentence, لَا تَقْرَبُوْا, would be grammatically complete. However, the intended meaning would not be conveyed.

Below are some examples of various قُيُوْدٌ.

مِثَالٌ	قَيْدٌ
﴿وَلَا تَقْرَبُوا الْفَوَاحِشَ﴾ *Do not come close to immoral acts.*	الْمَفْعُوْلُ بِهِ
﴿اذْكُرُوا اللّٰهَ ذِكْرًا كَثِيْرًا﴾ *Remember Allah abundantly.*	الْمَفْعُوْلُ الْمُطْلَقُ
﴿وَلَا تَقْتُلُوْٓا اَوْلَادَكُمْ خَشْيَةَ اِمْلَاقٍ ؕ﴾ *Do not kill your children for fear of poverty.*	الْمَفْعُوْلُ لَهُ
﴿قَالُوْا لَبِثْنَا يَوْمًا اَوْ بَعْضَ يَوْمٍ ؕ﴾ *They said, "We have stayed a day, or part of a day."*	الْمَفْعُوْلُ فِيْهِ
﴿فَوَرَبِّكَ لَنَحْشُرَنَّهُمْ وَالشَّيٰطِيْنَ﴾ *So, by your Lord! We will surely gather them along with the devils.*	الْمَفْعُوْلُ مَعَهُ
﴿لَا تَقْرَبُوا الصَّلٰوةَ وَاَنْتُمْ سُكٰرٰى﴾ *Do not go near Salah when you are intoxicated.*	حَالٌ
﴿فَلَنْ يُّقْبَلَ مِنْ اَحَدِهِمْ مِّلْءُ الْاَرْضِ ذَهَبًا﴾ *Even an Earth-full of gold shall never be accepted from any of them*	التَّمْيِيْزُ
﴿اَلْاَخِلَّآءُ يَوْمَئِذٍۢ بَعْضُهُمْ لِبَعْضٍ عَدُوٌّ اِلَّا الْمُتَّقِيْنَ ﴿٦٧﴾ ؕ﴾ *Friends, on that day, will become enemies to one another, except the God-fearing.*	الْمُسْتَثْنَى
﴿وَاَصْبَحَ فُؤَادُ اُمِّ مُوْسٰى فٰرِغًا ؕ﴾ *And the heart of the mother of Musa became restless.*	النَّوَاسِخُ
﴿وَاِنْ كُنْتُمْ فِيْ رَيْبٍ مِّمَّا نَزَّلْنَا عَلٰى عَبْدِنَا فَاْتُوْا بِسُوْرَةٍ مِّنْ مِّثْلِهٖ ۪﴾ *If you are in doubt about what We have revealed to Our servant, bring a Surah like this.*	الشَّرْطُ
﴿اَلَيْسَ اللّٰهُ بِاَحْكَمِ الْحٰكِمِيْنَ ﴿٨﴾ ؕ﴾ *Is Allah not the Greatest Ruler of all the rulers?*	النَّفْيُ

Part 2
Types of Sentences According to Grammar

A sentence can be analysed in two ways:

1) According to its grammar (Part 2)
2) According to its meaning (Part 3)

Types of Sentences According to Grammar

According to its grammar, there are two types of sentences:

1) جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ
2) جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ

In the study of Nahw, when a sentence starts with a noun, it is classified as a جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ regardless of the content of its خَبَرٌ. However, in Balagah, if a sentence begins with a noun and contains a فِعْلٌ in its خَبَرٌ, it will still be categorized as a جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ. This is because the focus of Balagah is on the meaning of the sentence, and the presence of a فِعْلٌ anywhere in the sentence gives the meaning of the verb.

	زَيْدٌ صَائِمٌ	زَيْنَبُ تَصُوْمُ	تَصُوْمُ زَيْنَبُ
عِلْمُ النَّحْوِ	اِسْمِيَّةٌ	اِسْمِيَّةٌ	فِعْلِيَّةٌ
عِلْمُ الْبَلَاغَةِ	اِسْمِيَّةٌ	فِعْلِيَّةٌ	فِعْلِيَّةٌ

A جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ represents a connection between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ, indicating that the مُبْتَدَأٌ possesses the characteristic described in the خَبَرٌ. For example, in the sentence الدَّرْسُ سَهْلٌ, we observe a relationship between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ i.e., the lesson being easy.

Tense of the Connections

The connections between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ can occur in any of the three tenses: past, present, or future.

Present Tense

The connection between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ can indicate a present tense link. This is the default tense of the جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ.

This type of connection is called ثُبُوْتٌ.

الرَّجُلُ قَائِمٌ

The man is standing.

Note

Sometimes, the present tense can depict a long-term meaning. This is called دَوَامٌ.

﴿اَلْحَمْدُ لِلّٰهِ رَبِّ الْعٰلَمِيْنَ ۙ﴾

All praise is for Allah, Lord of the worlds.

Past Tense

The connection between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ can also indicate a past tense link.

﴿اِنَّ اِبْرٰهِيْمَ كَانَ اُمَّةً قَانِتًا لِّلّٰهِ حَنِيْفًا ؕ﴾

Surely, Ibrahim was an Ummah.

This type of connection is called ثُبُوْتٌ فِي الْمَاضِيْ.

Future Tense

The connection between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ can also indicate a future tense link.

﴿إِنَّ الْمُتَّقِيْنَ فِيْ جَنّٰتٍ وَّعُيُوْنٍ ۝٢٥﴾

Surely, the God-Fearing will be in gardens and springs.

This type of connection is called ثُبُوْتٌ فِي الْمُسْتَقْبِلِ.

Note

The meaning of a جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ with كَانَ as its verb defaults to a link that existed in the past and has since ended. However, كَانَ can also indicate a link that is ongoing, as demonstrated in the following scenarios:

a) When the subject is the word Allah.

﴿وَكَانَ اللّٰهُ عَلِيْمًا حَكِيْمًا﴾

Allah is ever Knowing, Wise.

Here, the verb كَانَ implies that Allah has always possessed these qualities and will continue to possess them for eternity.

b) When the subject possesses a quality inherently.

﴿وَكَانَ الْاِنْسَانُ عَجُوْلًا﴾

Man is prone to be hasty.

In this case, the verb كَانَ indicates that man is predisposed to this particular trait.

c) When the sentence shows a certain future event. This is known as the Prophetic perfect tense.

﴿إِنَّ الْبَاطِلَ كَانَ زَهُوْقًا﴾

Surely, falsehood is ever bound to vanish (by its very nature).

Here, the verb كَانَ implies that the vanishing of falsehood is inevitable and bound to happen in the future.

Types of Connections

The connections between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ can be of two types:

1. ثُبُوْتٌ (stative)
2. دَوَامٌ (continuous)

ثُبُوْتٌ (stative)

This refers to a connection without any reference to its duration.

دَوَامٌ (continuous)

This refers to the establishment of a long-lasting connection.

﴿اَلْحَمْدُ لِلّٰهِ رَبِّ الْعٰلَمِيْنَ ۙ﴾

All praise is for Allah, Lord of the worlds.

In this verse, the connection between the مُبْتَدَأٌ and خَبَرٌ extends over a long period. This means that the quality of Allah being the Lord of the worlds is eternal.

جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ

A جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ shows the occurrence of an action.

There are two types of occurrences:

1. Single Occurrence (حُدُوْثٌ)
2. Repeated Occurrence (تَجَدُّدٌ)

Single Occurrence (حُدُوْثٌ)

حُدُوْثٌ is a single occurrence either in the past or future.

Simple Past Tense

﴿وَقَتَلَ دَاوٗدُ جَالُوْتَ﴾

And Dawud (David) killed Golliath.

Simple Future Tense

﴿ثُمَّ يَاْتِيْ مِنْۢ بَعْدِ ذٰلِكَ سَبْعٌ شِدَادٌ﴾

Then after that will come seven hard years.

Repeated Occurrence (تَجَدُّدٌ)

تَجَدُّدٌ is a repeated occurrence either in the past, present, or future.

Past Habitual Tense

﴿كَانَا يَاْكُلٰنِ الطَّعَامَ ؕ﴾

They used to eat food.

Present Habitual

﴿وَاللّٰهُ يَرْزُقُ مَنْ يَّشَآءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسَابٍ ۝٢١٢﴾

Allah gives whom He wills without counting.

Future Habitual

﴿وَلَكُمْ فِيهَا مَا تَشْتَهِيٓ أَنفُسُكُمْ وَلَكُمْ فِيهَا مَا تَدَّعُونَ ۝٣١﴾

And for you therein are whatever your souls desire, and for you therein is whatever you request.

Example

﴿وَإِذَا لَقُوا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا قَالُوٓا آمَنَّا ۚ وَإِذَا خَلَوْا إِلَىٰ شَيَاطِينِهِمْ ۙ قَالُوٓا إِنَّا مَعَكُمْ ۙ إِنَّمَا نَحْنُ مُسْتَهْزِئُونَ﴾

When they [the hypocrites] meet those who believe, they say, "We have entered Faith;" but when they are alone with their satans, they say, "Indeed, we are with you."

This verse contains two quotes from the hypocrites.

The first sentence is a جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ (آمَنَّا). When the hypocrites proclaimed their faith to the believers, it is hypocritical i.e. there is no ثُبُوْتٌ. Hence, their words are expressed using a جُمْلَةٌ فِعْلِيَّةٌ which depicts حُدُوْثٌ.

The second sentence is جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ (إِنَّا مَعَكُمْ). When the hypocrites express their affiliation with their evil companions, it accurately reflects their strong relationship, as it is based on evidence of their actions i.e. there is ثُبُوْتٌ. Hence, their words are expressed using a جُمْلَةٌ اسْمِيَّةٌ indicating the permanence and continuity of their association i.e., depicts ثُبُوْتٌ and دَوَامٌ.

حُدُوْثٌ and تَجَدُّدٌ in Nouns

The concept of ثُبُوْتٌ, حُدُوْثٌ and تَجَدُّدٌ also applies to a شِبْهُ الْفِعْلِ (i.e. اِسْمُ الْفَاعِلِ, اِسْمُ الْمَفْعُوْلِ and الصِّفَةُ الْمُشَبَّهَةُ بِاسْمِ الفاعِلِ).

Example

﴿وَاِذَا قَامُوْٓا اِلَى الصَّلٰوةِ قَامُوْا كُسَالٰى ۙ يُرَآءُوْنَ النَّاسَ﴾

And when they stand for Salah, they stand up lazily, only to show people

This verse portrays the salah of hypocrites in two ways: they are lazy, and they display their worship for show.

The first characteristic, laziness, is conveyed through a صِفَةٌ مُشَبَّهَةٌ بِاسْمِ الْفَاعِلِ which indicates a state of permanence, ثُبُوْتٌ. This shows that laziness is an enduring trait that persists throughout the entire prayer.

The second characteristic, showing off, is expressed through a verb that suggests recurrence or renewal, تَجَدَّدٌ. This shows that showing off is a behaviour that is repeated whenever there is an audience present.

Supplement: Interchanging فِعْلٌ مَاضٍ and فِعْلٌ مُضَارِعٌ

Using a فِعْلٌ مَاضٍ to Describe a Future Event

Sometimes, a فِعْلٌ مَاضٍ is used to describe a future event to indicate the certainty of that event.

﴿اَتٰٓى اَمْرُ اللّٰهِ فَلَا تَسْتَعْجِلُوْهُ﴾

The Event ordained by Allah will surely come to pass.

In this verse, the past tense verb أَتَى has been used in place of a مُضَارِعٌ to depict a future event. This emphasizes the inevitability of the future occurrence.

This style is commonly used in supplications:

جَزَاكَ اللهُ

The past tense of the verb جَزَى has been used in place of a مُضَارِعٌ to depict a future event. This emphasizes the hope of the speaker in the future occurrence.

May Allah reward you.

Using a فِعْلٌ مُضارِع to Describe a Past Event

Sometimes, a فِعْلٌ مُضَارِعٌ is used to describe a past event.

﴿فَفَرِيْقًا كَذَّبْتُمْ ۗ وَفَرِيْقًا تَقْتُلُوْنَ﴾

So, a faction (of Prophets) you denied, and a faction you kill.

In this verse, the past event of killing the messengers of Allah is described using the فِعْلٌ مُضَارِعٌ. This highlights the abomination of this action.

Part 3
Types of Sentences According to Meaning

According to its meaning, there are two types of sentences:

1) جُمْلَةٌ خَبَرِيَّةٌ
2) جُمْلَةٌ إِنْشَائِيَّةٌ

جُمْلَةٌ خَبَرِيَّةٌ

A جُمْلَةٌ خَبَرِيَّةٌ is a sentence which consists of information with a true or false value in accordance with reality.

For example, the sentence "The pen is broken" has a true or false value depending on whether the pen is broken or not.

﴿لَقَدْ اَرْسَلْنَا نُوْحًا اِلٰى قَوْمِهٖ﴾

Indeed, we sent Nooh to his people.

The sentence in this verse is a جُمْلَةٌ خَبَرِيَّةٌ; it comprises of information which can be checked with reality i.e. it has a true value.

﴿...لَيَقُوْلُوْنَ ۙ﴿١٥١﴾ وَلَدَ اللّٰهُ ۙ وَاِنَّهُمْ لَكٰذِبُوْنَ ﴿١٥٢﴾﴾

Indeed, they say, "Allah has given birth," and surely, they are liars.

The middle sentence in this verse is a جُمْلَةٌ خَبَرِيَّةٌ which has a false value; it is not in accordance with reality.

جُمْلَةٌ إِنْشَائِيَّةٌ

A جُمْلَةٌ إِنْشَائِيَّةٌ is a sentence which does not consist of information with a true or false value. Instead, it consists of commands, requests, etc.

For example, the sentence "Do not break the pen" is a command. It does not have a true or false value; it has no reality to be checked against.

﴿وَاَقِمِ الصَّلٰوةَ﴾

And establish salah.

Types of جُمْلَةٌ إِنْشَائِيَّةٌ

We will discuss the following types of جُمْلَةٌ إِنْشَائِيَّةٌ:

1) أَمْرٌ
2) نَهْيٌ
3) اِسْتِفْهَامٌ
4) تَمَنٍّ
5) تَرَجٍّ
6) نِدَاءٌ